



CONSTANT COMPANIONS

Here's what to pack your laptop with

If you've gotten yourself a laptop, you're on your way to accessorising! Here's a list of stuff you can buy for your laptop—some of which you can't live without, some just for fun.

Laptop case

Some laptops come with a carry case, some don't. The two most popular are carry cases and backpacks. While buying a case, check the padding in the main compartment—this is critical as it protects your laptop from jerks. Make sure your case can accommodate the charger and your other accessories. Extra space to take care of magazines or files is welcome!

Extra battery

This ensures you're never left high and dry with no computer. Pack one in when you intend to visit a place where charging may be a problem or where there are power cuts. If you need to use your laptop for extended periods of time on battery, opt for the more powerful 9-cell or 12-cell batteries. A 12-cell battery gives you double the operational time of a regular 6-cell battery. Before purchasing the extra

battery, make sure it's compatible with your laptop model. Compatibility details can be obtained from the laptop manual or from the manufacturer.

Laptop cooler

While in a desktop PC you have the option to add extra fans to take care of the heat, laptops have to rely on the fans integrated by the manufacturer. For those concerned about heat, you can try out laptop coolers. You just need to place your laptop on the cooler and connect its USB cable to your laptop. Typically, laptop coolers have two to four fans, and draw power from the USB port. Look for a cooler that allows you to adjust fan speed, so as to help reduce the noise level. Also see how comfortably you can use the laptop when it's mounted on the cooler. A USB hub on a cooler is an added plus.

Security alarm

Laptop security alarms use motion sensing to detect sudden movements with respect to the notebook. In case of any movement they let out a sound alarm.

External hard drive

These let you back up all your data at the press of a button—just connect the drive to your laptop and press the button, and voila—peace of mind! While selecting an external hard drive, check what capacities are available, then try and get a drive a bit bigger than the one on the laptop so that you can carry some extra data with you. Don't forget to check whether the drive comes with software that lets you back up your data automatically.

BUYER'S
Guide

Laptop speakers

You're probably not happy with the quality of sound offered by the inbuilt speakers. Just get external laptop speakers. Most of these use the USB interface for power as well as the audio signal. Remember, they'll reduce the battery life.

Car power adapter

A car power adapter for a laptop plugs in to the lighter port in your car and charges the laptop battery. This will make sure that you never run out of power.

Docking station

Laptop manufacturers offer docking stations for some models. Docks offer extra USB / FireWire ports, speakers, and connectors for an external display. If you want to expand your connectivity options. If there is no docking station for your model, look for compatible third-party docking stations. ■

Cool Accessories

Extra numeric keypad

Most laptops don't come with a numeric keypad, so you have to rely on the number keys on the standard keypad. For those who need to work with numbers, this can be tiring and possibly annoying... Did you know you could get a USB numeric keypad? These have big keys, so it's that much more convenient.

Laptop mouse

Touch-pads take some time to get used to, and even after you get used to them, they'll never, ever be as comfortable as a full-blown mouse. Not so full-blown,

though: we're talking about the little laptop mice you might have seen. To do your fingers a favour, choose from wired and wireless. Though smaller, laptop mice offer all the functionalities of their desktop counterparts.

Bluetooth headphones

Are these cool, or what? If you are on a wireless network and are using a wireless mouse, why not take the wireless motif a little further? Bluetooth headphones have an operating ranges of about 10 metres. They might be preferable in many cases to laptop speakers.